

School Committee Meeting Notes
Monday, August 17, 2020
6:00 PM Via Zoom

Executive Session 5:15 P.M. - 6:31 P.M.

Approval of minutes

Motion to approve the minutes by Melanie 2nd Kathy Kreatz

- 5 affirmative
- 2 abstaining--Paul Ruseau and Jenny Graham

Motion to approve bills and transfer funds

Motion made by Kathy Kreatz

7-0 motion passes

Secretary Notes

Nothing noteworthy at this time

Committee notes

- Meeting of the whole
- Community of the whole
- MTA Kreatz
- 2nd Vanderkloot
- Jenny Graham - abstain
- Paul Ruseau - abstain due to time to read not because of content
- 5-0 paper passes

MTA President - Charlene Douglas

- Thanked everyone for hard work
- Read a statement regarding the safety concerns of the mta for all
 - She noted she spoke on behalf of all the teachers
 - Referred to the Q & A and how it reflected negatively on the teachers
 - Need training, time, and resources to create a safe learning environment
 - Need to know HVAC, screens, ventilation, working sinks and other items of concern have been addressed
 - Referred to fire drills and lock down drills and weather and that COVID is interrupting education in the same way
 - MTA feels that the only safe way to reopen school is to do so remotely and then gradual work towards hybrid when it is safe
 - Welcomed David Murphy to the district
 - As a citizen and president of the MTA requests an independent audit of the MPS due to inaccuracies in the school budget
 - This needs to be complete for the 2020-2021 school year

- Looks forward to working together
- Paulette Van der Kloot
 - MPS values our teachers
 - She hears the concerns and responded to as many as possible
 - Wants to work positively...we are in this together
 - She understands its frustrating because its fluid...please bear with us
 - Want to work with everyone together
 - Thanked teachers and Charlene for all their hard work
 - Thanked all who reached out to her
- Melanie McLaughlin
 - Thank you Charlene for your comments on 8/6 and tonight
 - We hear you and you have genuine concerns about safety
 - Read excerpts from letters/emails sent to her
 - Wants more community involvement in this meeting
- Jenny Graham
 - Did not vote on the minutes because her focus was on the letters and emails that she received
 - The letter received by Charlene does not address COVID its reflects a budget that is not fully supported and its the fallout from that and not COVID
 - Teachers safety and student safety is paramount
 - Set expectations that we do not have all the answers tonight because things change so rapidly
- Kathy Kreatz
 - Apologized for not allowing Charlene to speak after the vote last meeting
 - There is so much to take in
 - So many worries regarding this reopening
 - Thank you to the parents and teachers and she is listening to all the concerns
- Breanna Lungo-Koehn
 - Thank you for advocating for your union
 - We will get there together
 - We will adapt and collaborate to do the best for our teachers and staff
- Jenny shared that Andy Paquette is underway on the budget audit since the July meeting motion passed
- Charlene spoke again--Jenny you're right we have been underfunded for years and we are here to work together to make things right
 - Discussed sister and family impact if we go remote
 - Honesty, respect, open communication and transparency is key
 - Wants to work together respectfully
- Paul Rousseau
 - SC email : read an email from a resident Laroche on Mystic Valley PKWY in regards to the staggered hybrid plan
 - Answers are found in the FAQ

Superintendent's Report

- 3 guiding pillars: safety, consistency, and equity
- Saturday--graduation class of 2020 from MHS
 - Thanks to Mr. Blouch Sr. AP, Fallon, Kingsley, D'Alleva, class advisors, Dr. Cushing, BOH, Toni Wray
 - Thanked Medford Media for their hard work
 - Thanked Medford team in the background to make it happen
 - Delivered diplomas to houses
 - Discussed the speakers of the day
 - Mustang community that came to help deliver ..thank you
 - We know it was not perfect, but we celebrate you
- Safety drove why we changed our plans
 - Our metrics have changed: Toni and Maryanne will give specifics later on in the meeting
 - Follow social distancing, masks and hand-washing protocols
- Parent/Caregiver Survey
 - Thank you to the families that replied 3800 responses in so far
- Yearbooks have gone out
- Welcome David Murphy to MPS as Asst. Supt of finance and operations
- Mass DOT to implement Safe Routes at Columbus and Roberts
- Thank you Mayor, Fallon Ambulance and BOH for the emergency testing for COVID testing at the high school. The line wrapped around the courtyard. Went from 2-7:30. This will happen again tomorrow and Wednesday from 2-7:30. This testing is free to help us understand our numbers. We encourage students, family and community to come get tested.
- Recommendation to the school committee based on metrics that have changed and we are in yellow. We look at remote learning for most students except our most vulnerable students possibly (special needs, EL, homeless, foster care, early childhood, Curtis Tufts and would like to consider including K) beginning with a hybrid opening on September 16th.
 - Opportunity to develop readiness skills
 - Revisit metrics in October and make a decision going forward at that time.
 - Feedback:
 - Melanie McLaughlin does not want a vote taken until we hear from the community.
 - 1st Melanie. 2nd Jenny 7-0 paper passes

Melanie McLaughlin says she can take the Good of order off of the table for tonight.

Maryanne O'Connor--BOH Report

- Made a decision due to the uncertainty of the situation and information that she was receiving
- Too many unknowns -- she needed to cancel graduation

- Our cases have risen 19 cases since 8/12
- Heading into the red--wont know if we are in red until Wednesday
- State says remote for red
- Thank you to all who came to get tested. Overwhelming response and will have additional testing for the next two days
- Concerned that people in contact with positive cases are refusing testing
- People need to do the right thing
- Tending in the wrong direction...we need to get this under control
- Admin did an amazing job with graduation
- She acknowledged that it was a tough decision

Q & A

Melanie McLaughlin:

Q: Any recourse if people test positive and refuse to quarantine?

A: Can order isolation for people and could be a police guard but that is extreme

Q: How does red remote from the state impact most vulnerable populations?

A: If we are red everyone's remote

Q: Do you know anything about other events at the hs this weekend

A: Yard sale is allowed with social distancing in yellow--if we turn red it could change and the church submitted a plan ahead of time that was approved previously to the uptick in numbers. This may need to be reviewed.

Q: We couldn't do Hormel, but why no drive up graduation.

A: Just could not risk it. I apologize but there were too many unknowns

Paulette: Wanted to clarify that the two events should not be combined they were very different

Toni Wray

- Thank you to Maryanne O'Connor
- Remember to follow guidelines for testing and quarantine
- Continue with preventive strategies
- In order to open schools safely we need diligence to prevention strategies

Michael Downs and Toni Wray COVID health screening guidelines

- Alpha Med Covid Care (free app)
- HIPA secure and compliant no personal data saved
- Can be used on a mobile device
- Set of questions
- Submit data between 6-6:30 every day (students and staff)
- If sent home sick must be tested before returning or stay home for 14 days
- School nurses will check in with families daily

- Please be honest when completing this daily
- We will get a report of who should not be in school each day
- Data goes to Toni Wray and the school nurses only and only if you are a red alert
- Identifies by LASID and not name
- Dr. Wexerman stresses that this needs to be done faithfully and honestly

Jenny Graham: asked how we think we can enforce this and what will the consequences be if people do not use it?

Toni: No good answer to that question. We can ask for additional reports from the company if needed. This info is only going to the school nurse and Toni Wray.

Peter reminded the community of the duty to care for each other to carry us through this pandemic.

Paulette Van der Kloot made a motion to send to Atty. Greenspan for his review of Alpha Med Covid Care app and if he has a positive opinion and if we can make it mandatory then we accept it.

7-0 paper approved

HVAC Report--John McLaughlin

- Arctic Engineering went through exhaust fans
 - B, MC, A finishing up on parts
 - Next week R, C
 - MHS working with electrical contractor to make needed repairs on roof
 - WB Engineering hired to go through ventilation at MHS
 - Report will follow

Mayor wants to know: Are we doing air quality testing as well?

- John says it's different when you have empty and full buildings
- Engineer could help us upgrade filters

Kathy Kreatz: Are they going to be sure that both the AC and heat are working?

Only have 2 people in the district doing what we can.

Does Kidz Korner have AC?

1 in infant and 2 in the older students

- Engineers will inspect every inch of the buildings. He does not anticipate major issues in the outside schools

Summer Enrichment Program--Paul Texeira

- Thanked the staff who worked hard to make this program a success
- Was 100% remote and was funded through title 3

Melanie McLaughlin double checked on the protocols that were followed

Updated ESY program report--Suzannah Campbell and Joan Bowen

- 170 students identified 62 most vulnerable and were offered in person with the remote
 - 47 opted in for the in person program
- July 13th staff were trained and given PPE and social distancing protocols were put in place
- July 20th small group or individual groups came in for services
- Parents / Caregivers came in and filled out pre-screening questionnaire before coming into building
- 4 students received transportation in an individual van
- Surveys conducted week of 8/3
 - 32 families
 - 26 staff
 - Trends: families found that packets ahead of time was helpful and praised service providers, consistent schedule worked well, pace of instruction was a point of discussion, confident in the ppe and drop off/arrival went smoothly
 - Staff survey: prep time used for asynchronous videos, online tools was successful, some students had a hard time engaging remotely, problematic internet connection

Updated Budget 2020-2021 Andy Paquette

- Welcome Atty. Dave Murphy looking forward to working together
- Going through contracts and personnel
- Grant funds have been released and will be meeting with grant administrators to go over budget
- Will be giving a more robust report as the year goes on
- EOY closeout positive \$27,800 general fund budget will be reclassified to carry over in circuit breaker
- Paul is ecstatic to receive a burn report to have a clear report on where they stand as a district

Return to School Survey- Peter, Suzanne and Tom

- Went through slide show--
 - Discussed goals of the survey: Hybrid vs. Remote, need for childcare, transportation, medical conditions, before/after school plans, electronic devices, internet
 - Discussed survey results per language
 - Principals will reach out to unresponsive families to fill out survey
 - Outreach strategies--imperative to have all families included in survey
 - Electronic distribution in 5 languages
 - Paper Survey/QR Code Flyer Distribution
 - Connections through other groups/organizations

Community Outreach Q & A

- Jessica H.: Why if it is not safe for all students to return is it ok for special ed students to return?

- Lynn Anderson: Graphic Arts senior should be in the building to get what he needs (Chad Fallon responded)
- Leticia Rocha: FAQ gave no new info: Why was the staggered remote voted on without community input? (Marice responded)
- Andrea Polcaro: prefer hybrid due to their soc/emo well being so please be aware that there are some families that are not pro-remote
- Kim: What is the plan to evaluate student progress? IS support? Will teachers be onsite teaching remotely? States that this remote plan goes against the state guidelines (Peter, Mayor, Paul D., Stacey S., and Suzanne answered her question)
- Michael Bernstein: Please let students stay within their schools during remote instruction. Do not divide us into cohorts now.
- Megan Bayer: Support the hybrid model...look at the whole health of the children. Remote is not equitable. Admin look at how we can pivot to a hybrid model if numbers support it.
- Kelly Catallo: Support hybrid model--parent of a senior please keep an open mind to hybrid model ... look at it differently for different groups of people...SATs on Oct. 3rd will that happen if we are remote?(Paul D. answered the question)
- Emails submitted to record:
 - James Donovan: some key points: Optimistic for in person learning--Remote learning was a failure--
 - Clare Baratch--Boston Latin school teacher/Brooks parent: please allow teachers to teach from home--trust that you have hired professional teachers--elementary schools keep classes together and loop together with the same teacher-- (Suzanne answered the question)
 - Angela Sasso--how do voke students get their hours in if they go remote?(Chad Fallon answered the question)
 - Florence Hamilton: Health App--can you clarify how it works in regards to the temperature? Will it be translated? (Toni Wray answered the question)
 - Gary Klein: MHS senior parent dismayed about the speaker at the graduation regarding women's right to choose and god--was controversial and should have been vetted. This was addressed to the superintendent. She answered the question. Apologized for not vetting the speaker's remarks.
- Mrs. Theresa Castagnetti: Why is it safe for the most vulnerable to be in school if we are in the red zone? How many numbers are we expecting in schools for this? Would we need more staff due to these numbers because of social distancing? (Superintendent answered)
- Allison Leed: Mayor, please think of the city as a whole...having the schools remote is going to increase the numbers more. Do we need to look at outside classrooms be an option? Are we considering routine testing for teachers and students? (Mayor answered)
- Kelly Catallo: Please consider this decision a 30 day review of the implementation plan.
- Kate Willard: Special Education teacher and resident, I would like more specifics what a most vulnerable student means? DESE definition is 75% or more of the day. What does that look like in MPS?

Paulette Van der Kloot::

- Paulette made a motion Jenny Graham seconded the motion. Roll call vote 7-0 motion passes.
- Paul Ruseau mentioned that the agenda did not list suspension so it will be on the next agenda.
- Melanie McLaughlin mentioned that the freshman sports is not on the agenda and needs to be put on the next meeting agenda.

New Business

Good of the Order--needs to be on the monthly agenda going forward. Can be tabled tonight, but should be on the first meeting of the month's agenda.

Paper tabled 7-0.

Community Involvement tabled until the next meeting.

Paper tabled 7-0.

Medford Hybrid/Remote start time

Tabled until next meeting.

Paper tabled 7-0.

Return to School Task Force dissolved except for the communications subcommittee.

If you would like to be a part of the communications subcommittee please email Tom M. by 8/24.

Melanie would like to amend that the subcommittee will meet weekly and hold 2-4 roundtables before school begins and 2-4 roundtable meetings after school begins.

MASC delegates to the conference in Hyannis.

Paulette nominated Melanie and Paul to be the delegate representing Medford.

7-0..motion passes.

Rousseau made a motion to adjourn. Seconded by McLaughlin. 7-0 meeting adjourned at 10:41.